

cute a file or anything like that. Still, I'd been so panicky! To top it all, this is my home computer—not the office computer where I store all my important work data!

Several days of discussions and debates with colleagues and friends got me believing that I'm insane... the majority of my friends and colleagues found nothing wrong with my reaction—spilt tea and all! Others just felt that I'd overreacted a “tad,” and were OK with me panicking, but chided me about my carelessness in stepping on spilt tea!

Six lectures about why I shouldn't fill my tea cup to the brim, and two homemade recipes for stain removal later, I was appalled to find that I was the only one who could see the pointlessness of all this paranoia.

At the risk of starting World War III, I have now started to believe that all these fears we have about computer security have been infused into our collective psyche by clever security software marketing, rumour-mongers, and because of sheer ignorance!

A Bold Statement?

Yes, it is, but I have reasons to believe so. No, I am *not* another “Big Brother is watching” delusional psychopath. Actually, I just couldn't care less for Big Brother's antics, or those of the rest of the family!

I am not saying that spyware, adware and viruses are encouraged by security software developers, but isn't it just a little too convenient that security firms benefit from all the paranoia raging across the world, with more people buying their products—even for home systems which don't need such high levels of protection? Thank God for the free software movement, which makes sure those informed enough can always find freeware tools to take care of basic PC security at home.

“What possible use could anyone make of the data stored on my home computer?”, I asked myself. I am still waiting for an answer that justifies my erstwhile paranoia. The only possible way my computer could be at risk is if it were controlled by a hacker to launch DDoS (Distributed Denial of Service) attacks, or used to spam a million people; and I think I'd notice if that started happening—courtesy my bandwidth monitor, anti-virus, anti-spam, anti-spyware, and various other “anti-” tools.

Right about now, scores of people are yelling “Hypocrite!” and waving their clenched fists at me. How can I have all this installed and still say that I am not paranoid about security anymore? Well, it's my *state of mind* I have changed, not my *computer or software preferences*. I am no extremist, and am not about to start uninstalling every software that begins with the word “anti-”. I'd still rather not be attacked by malware, but if I am, I'm not going to consider it the onset of Doomsday!

The Psyche

There's just one question all of us need to ask ourselves, “What's so important on our home computers that we're terrified of malicious code?” Office computers, or computers in a SoHo setup, need to have increased security. This is understandable. However, do regular home computers, those we use just to check e-mail, play games, surf, watch movies, etc., really need government-level security?

Exaggeration? Perhaps! But surely there are enough of us who would like the RBI's security system for our home computers, right?

The problem lies in the fact that we're terrified of losing data, having to format, or face the invasion of our privacy by spyware. And this fear, I aver, has been instilled in us by trends in the security software industry, the media, as well as a lot of hearsay and sensationalism of security breaches.

Isn't it weird that “a friend of a friend” has always had a nightmare virus hit them, one that formatted their entire hard disk and loaded Linux on it? Or how about that story of the virus that ruined someone's *hardware*, causing things like graphics cards and CD-ROMs to never work again? You will even find people who swear that a friend's mobile phone was rendered useless by a virus which sent lewd SMSes to all people in the contact list, then displayed a laughing skull and shut the phone down for good! Perhaps you'll like the one about another “friend-of-a-friend” who lost control of his/her computer to a hacker, and even pulling the power plug didn't relinquish command back to the user! If you haven't met such people, or heard similar stories,

either all your friends are super techie, or you live high up somewhere in the Himalayas!

“Balderdash, drivell and baloney, flavoured with hogwash!” is my reaction to such stories, but unfortunately, there are people among us who swallow such servings with relish and pass them on with a dash of exaggerated side-dishes. Sadly, this is just because we don't know any better, and are still perplexed by a PC's complexities.

Life After Data

What's the worst that could happen? This is the question that made me realise that adding all that stress and worry into my life, about my computer at home, was just not worth it. I sat down, thought out all the possible scenarios, and realised that life would go on, with or without my data. Here are the worst-case scenarios I came up with:

Formatting and reinstalling: Surprisingly, it is this irritation of having to unload and load a whole operating system that seemed the most painful. What's more surprising is that as employees of *Digit*,

we're used to formatting and reinstalling on a regular basis—the Test Centre guys do it as many as 10 times a day! So why was I so scared of doing the same thing at home? It's just a question of popping in your Windows boot disk, formatting your C: drive (or whatever is your Windows drive) and following a few silly commands—twenty minutes tops!

Data loss: Sure, there's always the risk of losing data, especially from your Windows drive. But why would you store anything on that drive? I know I don't. I make sure all my data is on a different partition, so the only thing I lose is time, which is spent on reinstalling my programs.

Reinstalling programs: This can be very painful, but thanks to Windows XP's System Restore, or third-party utilities such as Norton Ghost, life can be a lot easier. All you need to do is select a point to restore Windows to, or if you use a utility such as Norton Ghost, create a backup image, save it on another partition and then load it as and when you want to get a perfectly clean system. The trick is to format the computer, load all the essential software that you use regularly, and then make a backup image!

